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Reforming Research Assessment CoARA Action Plan University of Geneva 2025-2027

March 2025

Status: Approved by the Rectorate of the University of Geneva

Version 1

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Date: 12 March 2025

Introduction

The University of Geneva signed in 2023 the **Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment (ARA)** led by the **Coalition for Advancing Research Assessment (CoARA)**. The Agreement aims to transform how research, researchers and research organisations are evaluated by shifting the focus from quantitative metrics to more qualitative and comprehensive criteria that recognize diverse research contributions to science and society, as well as responsible and collaborative research practices. Its goal is to foster research excellence based on a fair and responsible research culture. ARA signatories commit to enabling a systemic reform based on common principles and to collaborating across institutions to implement these reforms. They set out their commitment in an **Action Plan** that outlines specific initiatives and timelines.

The present Action Plan builds on activities and discussions that have been taking place at the **University of Geneva** for several years now, such as the inclusion of equality delegates in nomination committees and the introduction of narrative CVs by the faculties of Medicine and Social Sciences. Its goal is to expand and strengthen these initiatives by creating a space for reflection and exchange on responsible research assessment and establishing a common framework on which the different entities of the University can work. These efforts don't imply abandoning quantitative metrics based on journal impact factors but complementing them with qualitative and diverse criteria in order to foster a fairer and more comprehensive evaluation system that supports academic excellence encompassing scientific rigor and ethics, originality and relevance, as well as collaborative and sound management practices ¹.

Scope and guiding principles of UNIGE Action Plan

The CoARA Agreement addresses the specific challenges of reforming research assessment at multiple levels, including researchers, research entities (e.g. research groups, institutes, centres or departments), and research organisations. In alignment with this framework, UNIGE's Action Plan focuses on three distinct but interconnected levels of research assessment practices:

1. Individual Researchers

The Action Plan addresses assessment processes used in hiring processes and career promotion and renewals. It aims to rethink methodologies, tools, and criteria to better assess researchers' diverse contributions to science and society (e.g. contextualized and structured Curriculum).

2. Research entities

The Action Plan will provide an opportunity to reflect on how research is monitored and assessed at the levels of research groups, institutes, centres or departments. This includes examining the purposes, methods and tools for assessing research as a collective endeavour such as through Scientific Advisory Boards.

3. The University

At the institutional level, the Action Plan will encourage a critical reflection on how research activities are evaluated, for instance during accreditation processes. It also aims to critically discuss international rankings, ensuring these evaluations align with the principles of responsible research assessment.

¹ See the Swiss National Foundation's Model of Excellence (<https://www.snf.ch/en/tf8nnJBdUJPCYODI/topic/the-snsfs-model-of-excellence>)

The efforts towards reforming research assessment align with strategic directions of the University of Geneva related to excellence, to open science, to equality, diversity and inclusivity, to responsible research and to interdisciplinarity². UNIGE Action Plan integrates these discussions in **5 guiding principles** for research assessment:

- 1. Promotion of excellence through comprehensive research assessment:** research excellence goes beyond outputs and includes research culture as a whole, i.e. conceptual and analytical thinking, methodologies, and professional practices and behaviour (e.g. collaboration, leadership, communication). Research assessment should reflect these diverse dimensions to support excellence.
- 2. Integration of open science into research assessment:** The transition to open science is currently hindered by traditional research evaluation systems, which often rely on bibliometric indices that can be influenced by biases related to the prestige of journals or publishers. Reforming research assessment is therefore crucial to embedding open science practices into the core of research activities.
- 3. Aligning research assessment with equality, diversity, and inclusivity goals:** reforming research assessment with criteria going beyond journal metrics supports equality, diversity and inclusion (EDI) goals.
- 4. Incorporating responsible research into research assessment:** by focusing on responsible research, evaluation criteria not only measure scientific excellence but also consider the broader impacts of research on society, the environment, and the economy.
- 5. When appropriate, recognising the value of interdisciplinarity and the originality of scientific profiles:** by valuing interdisciplinary research and less acknowledged research domains, research evaluation can better recognize and reward people and projects that address problems from diverse perspectives and through collaborative efforts.

Challenges

The shift from traditional, quantitative metrics towards more qualitative and multidimensional criteria faces several barriers, which require careful consideration and cooperation among all stakeholders to ensure the implementation of the principles set by the Agreement on Research Assessment.

- **Disciplinary diversity:** Academic disciplines vary greatly in their research methods and outputs; they use their own evaluation standards, methodologies, and metrics. Reforming research evaluation requires a nuanced approach that recognizes and respects these differences.
- **Faculty autonomy:** The University of Geneva's organisational structure grants significant autonomy to its faculties and interfaculty centres. While this allows for research assessment practices to be tailored to the specific needs of each discipline, it also presents challenges in implementing overarching reforms across the institution.

² University of Geneva, Strategic plan 2024-2034 (see <https://www.unige.ch/en/university/politique-generale/plan-strategique/>)

- **Resources:** Evaluating research using a wide range of criteria is time consuming. Additionally, it necessitates training for evaluators and new tools for assessment.
- **International competition:** Researchers operate in a global environment where their success depends on widely recognized assessment criteria, predominantly metrics. Reforming research assessment must strike a balance between embracing innovative evaluation methods and upholding internationally accepted standards.
- **Metrics-driven culture:** The reliance on traditional metrics like publication counts and journal impact factors is deeply rooted in certain disciplines. Shifting to more qualitative and diverse evaluation criteria could represent a significant cultural change.

Involvement of UNIGE community in advancing research assessment

Until now, discussions and initiatives to reform research evaluation at UNIGE have been largely driven by faculty-led efforts, while aligning with the rectorate's strategic priorities, including open science, equality, and diversity.

The Action Plan aims to build on this approach by fostering collaboration between faculty initiatives and institutional objectives. Several key bodies will contribute to these efforts, ensuring a shared vision of the multidimensional nature of research, including :

- Faculties
- Research and Grants Office
- Human Ressources Division
- Open Science Steering Committee
- Delegation for Equal Opportunities in Appointment Professoral Procedures

UNIGE Action Plan

The implementation of the CoARA Agreement at the University of Geneva requires thorough reflection and dialogue with faculties and academic support services. This process shall build on past and ongoing discussions about the various dimensions of research assessment such as research ethics, career paths, inclusivity and diversity, open science and more, both at institutional and faculty levels. The Action Plan, therefore, seeks to engage all relevant stakeholders to establish a framework for research assessment reform that is not only aligned with CoARA principles but also reflects the specific needs and values of UNIGE's academic community.

In practice, UNIGE Action Plan must be understood as a “living document”. In the current iteration, it outlines **general actions aimed at defining orientations for the institution and initiating a dialogue on pathways for reforming research assessment**. Its time horizon extends to the end of 2026, and it is intended to be updated with further actions involving the entire UNIGE community. We believe that the transformation of the evaluative culture should be approached through iterative processes over an extended period of time.

	Action	Objective(s)	Responsible(s)	Milestones	Deliverables	ARA commitment
1	Establish a “Reforming Research Assessment” working group (RRA group)	Provide a space for developing a framework to guide discussions and reflections on Research Assessment at UNIGE. Ensure consultation and coordination between involved actors Ensure dissemination in faculties and services Get (human) resources to implement part of the Action Plan	Rectorate	June 2025	RRA group established	#5

2	Define research excellence and how to assess research excellence in career paths.	Define the dimensions of research excellence in general and at faculty/disciplines levels	Faculties	Spring 2026	Faculties reports (1 page?)	#2 #3 #6
		Investigate concrete tools, methods and process to incorporate the dimensions of research excellence in assessment	Rectorate, with RRA group	June 2026	Synthesis document for ongoing discussion (Rectorate)	
3	Publish an institutional document/Charter for responsible research assessment	Establish a framework and guiding principles to foster a research culture that recognizes and value the multidimensionality of research. Promote awareness of research multidimensionality and support the reform of research assessment	Rectorate, with RRA group	Early 2026	First draft of the document	#1 #7
				Spring 2026	Consultation and improvement	
				Summer 2026	Institutional document published	
4	Explore possible mechanisms to assess research entities (e.g. establishment of scientific advisory boards or other types of mechanisms). Various types of research entities may be considered, depending on faculty culture and structure.	Investigate concrete frameworks for evaluation. This involves exploring specific processes, structures, and best practices for effective implementation.	Faculties	Spring 2026	Faculties reports/positions (1 page max?)	#6
			Research and Grants Service/Rectorate and RRA Group	Early 2027	Synthesis document	

5	Review the use of rankings and provide recommendations	Evaluate the relevance of international rankings in the context of research multidimensionality, considering both quantitative and qualitative criteria, as well as ethics, academic freedom, collaboration, and other core values. Establish recommendations for the Rectorate	Rectorate	Summer 2026	Report	#4
			RRA Group (based on a wide consultation)	Spring 2027	Recommendations	